

Artisans giving final touches to terracota horses.

Exquisite Terracottas at Four-Day Workshop

MADRAS

From the Indus valley culture (finds at Mohanjadaro and Harappa) dating from the Third Millenium B.C. down to our day, the great sculptural tradition of India runs like a perennial stream with slight local variations. The small bronze of the dancer with its linear rhythm, the bend of the left leg, the curved left arm, as well as the delicate balance of the torso, the pottery and the terracotta pieces, seals and figurines of men and animals, testify to a glorious heritage.

The excellent collection of terracotta pieces assembled in the four wings of the Lalit Kala Gallery, Greams Road, gives us a clue to this artistic skill and the complex and diverse religious symbolism, myths and legends of this vast sub-continent. In an effort to promote and stimulate an interest and an awareness of the crafts of India, the Crafts Council of India has organised this exhibition with a four-day workshop.

The plastic art of India finds a new expression at the hands of these skilled potters and carvers from different parts of the country, with local tint and technique. The workmen demonstrated their skills by carving many figures and utensils in temporary tents put up in the campus. After drying in the hot sun, they were put into a huge kiln and fired.

Some of the freshly made terracottas were shown to a group of Pressmen who went round the artists' camp. Here, as in the days of old, the anonymous artists transferred their ever-fresh enthusiasm to clay and mud with unabated zest for life, enjoyment of elegance and appreciation of beauty, giving it a local habitation and a name.

Craftsmen From West Bengal

Representing the cream of the artisans, the gathering included workmen from West Bengal, who carved stylised figures like "Bankura Horses and Elephants", artisans from Assam who designed dolls, flower vases, conches and ash-trays and those from Kutch district (in Gujarat), made "tavadi" and "tabak" plates, table wares and water vessels. The workers from Azamgarh district, in U.P. specialised in plates, beakers, jugs, cups and saucers of different sizes and shapes. The "modas", flower pots, temple cars, lamp shades and masks, made by workers from Karnataka were in soft and delicate shades of red and deep brown. They were beautiful and elegant.

Village Gods

Towering above all these stood the graceful horses and elephants with riders and bulls with bent horns, twisted tongues and squat legs, made by carvers of Satyamangalam; with strings of brass bells round their necks and delicate ornamentation they presented an impressive array. The skilled artisans of Tamil Nadu came from such chief centres like Cuddalore, Thanjavur, Kumbakonam, Sakkottai, Mariammankoil, Tiruchencode and Satyamangalam near Pudukottai. A refreshing feature of this group are the terracottas of village gods and deities like "Madurai Veeran, Irulan, Katteri, Sangili Karuppan and Chamundi". The huge horses made by the workers of Kosapalayam (Pondicherry) deserve special mention in this group.

The superb creations of C. Tirunavukkarasu, to mention a skilled artisan of "Poompuhar" (Madras Design Centre) with delicately carved features of ornaments and drapery included a beautiful "Deepa Lakshmi" and seated "Madurai Veeran" apart from masks of demons with an aggressive countenance.

The Crafts Council also conducted interaction between the potters and various select groups of professionals such as designers and artists and sociologists and housewives.

The Exhibition organised by the Crafts Council of India and the All India Handicrafts Board will be declared open by Mr. Sadiq Ali, Governor of Tamil Nadu on February 14 at 5 p.m. It will be on view till Feb. 19, daily from 10 a.m. to 1 p.m. and 3 p.m. to 7 p.m.



A foreign visitor evincing interest in a potter at the wheel.

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